Strategic Technology Programs for State and Local Government

Aligning Modernization Initiatives with Federal Funding Streams (2026-2030)

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The state and local government (SLG) technology landscape is undergoing a profound and rapid transformation, catalyzed by an unprecedented intersection of advanced technological capabilities and shifting federal funding paradigms. The passage of the "One Big Beautiful Bill Act" (OBBBA) in 2025 has fundamentally altered the fiscal architecture of public sector information technology.[1] While the legislation introduces significant reductions in baseline social safety net funding—including a projected $911 billion to $1 trillion cut to Medicaid over a decade and $187 billion in cuts to the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP)—it simultaneously injects hundreds of billions of dollars into highly targeted, technology-dependent modernization programs.[1]

For Dell and SLG strategists, this fiscal dichotomy presents a clear and urgent mandate. State agencies are under immense pressure to deploy artificial intelligence (AI), edge computing, and advanced data analytics not merely as innovative pilot programs, but as existential operational necessities designed to bridge widening funding gaps and maintain critical service delivery.[5] From the $50 billion Rural Health Transformation Program (RHTP) to the $12.5 billion modernization of the Federal Aviation Administration's (FAA) air traffic control systems, and the infusion of over $1.1 billion into mega-event security for the 2026 FIFA World Cup and 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, SLG technology procurement is heavily indexed toward scalable, secure, and AI-ready infrastructure.[7]

This comprehensive research report provides an exhaustive analysis of the predominant federal funding streams, top state Chief Information Officer (CIO) priorities, and localized modernization mandates. It identifies actionable programmatic alignments for Dell's strategy and marketing teams, focusing on the specific architectural, hardware, and software requirements generated by these macroeconomic shifts. By mapping Dell's unique capabilities directly to funded state initiatives, we can transition from traditional vendor relationships to essential strategic enablers.

The State IT Strategic Horizon: Analyzing Top CIO and Gubernatorial Priorities

To effectively position technology programs, it is critical to align them with the stated strategic priorities of state IT leadership and executive branches. The National Association of State Chief Information Officers (NASCIO) recently released its 2026 State CIO Top 10 Priorities, revealing a historic shift in the technological hierarchy.[10] For the first time in twelve years, Cybersecurity was dethroned from the number one position, replaced by Artificial Intelligence, which explicitly includes Agentic AI.[10][15]

This shift does not indicate a diminished focus on security; rather, it reflects an underlying consensus that AI has become the primary vector for both operational transformation and emerging security vulnerabilities.[12] Unlike standard generative AI, agentic AI allows systems to autonomously plan actions and coordinate tasks across government workflows, which state IT

leaders are increasingly adopting to reduce administrative friction and simplify operations amidst severe workforce shortages. State CIOs recognize that AI governance, data architecture, and workforce readiness must be established immediately to absorb the impending wave of these AI-driven applications across all verticals.[14]

NASCIO 2026 Policy & Strategic Priorities	**NASCIO 2026 Priority Technologies, Applications, and Tools**
1. Artificial Intelligence / GenAI / Agentic AI / Machine Learning	1. Artificial Intelligence
2. Cybersecurity & Risk Management	2. Application Modernization / Renovation
3. Budget / Cost Control / Fiscal Management	3. Cloud Solutions
4. Modernization	4. Identity and Access Management (IAM)
5. Digital Government / Digital Services	5. Software-as-a-Service (SaaS)
6. Accessibility	6. Security Enhancement Tools
7. Identity & Access Management	7. Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP)
8. Data Management & Analytics	8. Data Management
9. Consolidation / Optimization	9. Data Analytics

10. Cloud Services	10. Networking

Data sourced from NASCIO 2026 State Top 10 Priorities.[15][15]

Budget and Cost Control has notably risen to the third strategic priority, directly reflecting the fiscal constraints imposed by OBBBA and the sunsetting of pandemic-era federal relief funds.[11] Consequently, SLG strategists must frame technology solutions—particularly AI, legacy application modernization, and cloud consolidation—as mechanisms for aggressive cost avoidance and workforce multiplication rather than mere technological upgrades.[5]

At the executive level, the National Governors Association (NGA) 2025-2026 Chair's Initiative, spearheaded by Oklahoma Governor Kevin Stitt, is titled "Reigniting the American Dream".[16] The initiative focuses on three foundational pillars: Unlocking Economic Opportunity, Empowering Every Learner, and Energizing the Future.[16] The third pillar explicitly focuses on powering America's AI future and energy independence.[16] Technology programs that successfully map to these gubernatorial pillars will find stronger executive sponsorship within statehouses.

Reimagining Education Amidst OBBBA Financial Pressures

The education vertical represents a critical frontier for SLG modernization, heavily influenced by both executive initiatives and looming financial constraints. The NGA's "Reigniting the American Dream" initiative features a core pillar titled "Empowering Every Learner."[17] This pillar focuses on reimagining education to equip learners for a changing world and building flexible, future-ready workforce pathways, such as hands-on learning and technical education.[17]

However, provisions within the OBBBA are projected to place significant strain on state budgets, posing a direct threat to district education spending in 2026. With proposed multi-billion dollar cuts to federal education funding and sweeping Medicaid and SNAP reductions that affect school reimbursements and holistic student support, school districts are being forced to make tough, holistic budgeting choices. This intense financial pressure will drive districts to seek cost-saving technologies, aggressive IT consolidation, and highly efficient digital learning platforms. This presents a distinct opportunity for Dell's education strategists to position infrastructure solutions that lower total cost of ownership (TCO) while preserving the digital pathways necessary for modern learning.

The $50 Billion Rural Health Transformation Program

(RHTP)

One of the most significant programmatic opportunities currently available in the SLG sector is the Rural Health Transformation Program (RHTP). Established under Section 71401 of the OBBBA, the RHTP directs $50 billion over five fiscal years (FY2026–FY2030) to stabilize, innovate, and modernize rural healthcare delivery ecosystems.[7]

Legislative Mechanics and Funding Distribution

The $10 billion annual allocation is meticulously structured to incentivize both baseline geographic modernization and highly competitive clinical innovation. Fifty percent of the funding ($5 billion annually) is distributed equally among all states with approved transformation plans, guaranteeing a baseline of $100 million per state, per year.[18] The remaining 50% is allocated at the discretion of the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services (CMS) based on a complex algorithm of factors including the proportion of rural populations, rural facility density, and the financial operating margins of hospitals within the state.[18]

Because the secondary $5 billion pool is fiercely competitive, state governments are heavily incentivizing their rural healthcare coalitions to propose advanced, technology-forward clinical models. The statutory language of the OBBBA explicitly requires states to "prioritize the use of new and emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence (AI), emphasizing prevention and chronic disease management".[19]

Enterprise Technology Requirements for Rural Healthcare

Executing these state RHTP plans requires robust enterprise hardware and decentralized edge computing infrastructure. Traditional clinical IT architectures frequently fail in rural environments due to broadband instability.

RHTP Technology Initiative	Clinical Objective	Enterprise Infrastructure Requirement
Advanced Telehealth Systems	Expand specialty care access and reduce patient transit times.	Ruggedized telemedicine carts equipped with high-definition diagnostic peripherals, supported by resilient edge servers for local caching and video processing.[23]
Remote Patient	Real-time tracking of chronic conditions	Secure Internet of Medical Things (IoMT) gateways,

Monitoring (RPM)	(hypertension, diabetes) to prevent acute hospital readmissions.	hyper-converged infrastructure capable of ingesting high-velocity unstructured data streams, and zero-trust network access.[24]
Hybrid Networking & Failover	Ensure continuity of care amidst unreliable rural broadband infrastructure.	SD-WAN architectures integrating fiber, cellular hotspots, and satellite connectivity, alongside localized compute resources to maintain operations during network severances.[26]
Rural Cybersecurity Hardening	Protect vulnerable, underfunded regional hospitals from ransomware and data breaches.	Advanced Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR), immutable backup storage arrays, and automated patch management systems integrated into state health information exchanges.[27]

Derived from RHTP statutory requirements and rural health technology best practices.[19]

Mega-Event Infrastructure Readiness: 2026 FIFA World Cup and 2028 Olympic Games

The impending 2026 FIFA World Cup and the 2028 Los Angeles Olympic Games represent a massive influx of specialized federal funding aimed at host cities, regional transit authorities, and state law enforcement agencies.

FIFA World Cup 2026 Security and Threat Mitigation Grants

To prepare for the 104 matches occurring across the North American host cities, the OBBBA established the FIFA World Cup Grant Program (FWCGP). This program appropriates $625 million to enhance security, emergency preparedness, and technological capabilities across the 11 U.S. host cities.[8] The funding mandates 100% distribution to local Host City Committee Task Forces within 45 days of receipt.[8]

Simultaneously, the federal government authorized a dedicated $500 million

Counter-Unmanned Aircraft Systems (C-UAS) Grant Program to detect, track, and mitigate aerial drone threats over stadiums and fan zones.[30] Host cities are actively procuring infrastructure to support "Multi-Modal, Multi-Source AI Fusion," aggregating disparate data streams into unified command centers.[31]

C-UAS Technology Component	Operational Function	Enterprise Infrastructure Requirement
Radio Frequency (RF) Detection	Intercepts communication signals between drones and terrestrial controllers to provide early warning and telemetry data.	Edge-deployed sensors requiring low-latency network uplinks and local compute to parse RF spectrum anomalies.[32]
Radar Systems	Tracks physical movement (range, speed, altitude, flight path) even when the drone operates autonomously.	High-throughput data ingestion pipelines; localized GPU-accelerated servers for real-time spatial anomaly detection.[32]
Electro-Optical/Infrared (EO/IR)	Provides visual confirmation of aerial threats, day or night, validating radar and RF detections.	Ultra-high-density storage arrays for uncompressed 4K video streams; high-performance compute for real-time AI computer vision analysis.[32]
Remote ID Receivers	Reads broadcast identification from compliant drones to separate authorized flights from unknown threats.	Secure integration gateways linking field receivers to municipal Real-Time Crime Centers (RTCCs).[32]

Los Angeles 2028 Olympics and Smart City Investments

While the World Cup focuses heavily on immediate physical security, the Los Angeles 2028 Olympics is driving a broader "Smart City" and intelligent transportation infrastructure overhaul. The "Twenty-Eight by '28" initiative encompasses clean energy grid resilience, automated transportation, and digital equity.[33] Transportation analysts predict a heavy reliance on agentic AI and edge computing to manage intelligent traffic systems, optimize autonomous

vehicle routing, and mitigate congestion during the Games.[36]

Operationalizing AI for Entitlement Program Integrity and Fraud Detection

Faced with a staggering 12% reduction in federal matching funds under OBBBA, state healthcare program integrity leaders are under extreme pressure to maintain oversight for patient care while controlling healthcare fraud.[6] The Government Accountability Office (GAO) estimates that federal and state grant programs lose between $233 billion to $521 billion annually due to fraud, waste, and abuse (FWA).[5]

The Evolution of Medicaid Fraud Control Units (MFCUs)

State Medicaid Fraud Control Units (MFCUs), operating primarily under State Attorneys General, represent the frontline defense against healthcare fraud. In FY2026, the 53 MFCUs received a combined federal operational budget estimate of $432 million to support the procurement of advanced IT systems and data analytics.[37] Historically reliant on manual audits, MFCUs are rapidly procuring AI-driven analytics platforms to conduct proactive, real-time fraud detection.[5] These systems ingest massive volumes of claims data to identify subtle billing anomalies and detect sophisticated algorithmic upcoding.[6]

Sovereign AI and Dell Infrastructure Requirements

Because MFCUs handle highly sensitive Protected Health Information (PHI) and Personally Identifiable Information (PII), there is a strong preference for secure, on-premises infrastructure or dedicated sovereign cloud AI environments.[38] To meet this exact need, agencies can leverage the Dell AI Factory with NVIDIA, which provides a reference design specifically tailored for government agencies to accelerate secure, scalable AI adoption from pilot to production. Dell's Sovereign AI solutions ensure that public sector entities maintain full control and ownership of their AI capabilities, data, and agentic workflows in environments where strict regulatory compliance and security are non-negotiable.

Public Safety Modernization: Real-Time Crime Centers and Law Enforcement AI

Paralleling the mega-event security trend, permanent Real-Time Crime Centers (RTCCs) are proliferating across medium and large municipalities, heavily subsidized by Department of Justice (DOJ) grants.[41] RTCCs function as the central nervous system for municipal public safety, ingesting data from CCTV, automatic license plate readers (ALPR), and drone-as-a-first-responder (DFR) programs.[43]

Sending continuous, high-definition video streams to a centralized cloud introduces

unacceptable latency and saturates bandwidth.[45] Consequently, RTCC architecture is rapidly shifting toward distributed edge computing. Hardware must be deployed closer to the sensor, processing raw video using AI locally, and sending only relevant metadata back to the centralized RTCC command center.[45] Furthermore, as concerns over surveillance overreach escalate, federated learning models are emerging, allowing multiple jurisdictions to collaboratively train AI without transferring raw, privacy-sensitive data across boundaries.[45]

Intelligent Transportation and Smart Cities Amidst Funding Shifts

The OBBBA legislation transferred over $200 million away from the Strengthening Mobility and Revolutionizing Transportation (SMART) grant program, redirecting funds to broader highway infrastructure programs.[47] Despite these targeted grant reductions, the demand for intelligent transportation systems (ITS) continues to grow. State and local agencies are turning to agentic AI and edge computing to manage traffic flow dynamically, reduce idling emissions, and prioritize emergency vehicle routing without the need for massive, centralized infrastructure overhauls.[36]

Federal Aviation Modernization (BNATCS) and State-Level Airport Impacts

The OBBBA appropriated a historic $12.5 billion in emergency supplemental funding to replace the FAA's critically aged infrastructure through the "Brand New Air Traffic Control System" (BNATCS).[2] While fundamentally a federal initiative executed by prime contractors, the deployment heavily impacts local airport authorities and state-owned aviation infrastructure, creating secondary procurement opportunities.

The BNATCS program encompasses several massive IT infrastructure replacement projects [2]:

- **$1 Billion** for Terminal Radar Approach Control (TRACON) recapitalization.
- **$500 Million** to install the Surface Awareness Initiative (SAI) systems at 200 airports.
- **$300 Million** to replace obsolete IT hardware reliant on outdated formats.
- **$100 Million** for the FAA’s Tower Simulation System (TSS) at 113 air traffic control towers.

The enterprise hardware specifications required for these deployments are exceptionally rigorous. Systems must support complex virtualization (VMware/Hyper-V), sophisticated storage redundancy, and be housed in specialized rackmount chassis designed to meet extreme MIL-STD mechanical engineering requirements for vibration and cooling.[52]

Navigating Cybersecurity, Governance, and

Regulatory Compliance

Cybersecurity remains the foundational layer upon which all SLG modernization efforts depend. The federal government recognized this vulnerability with the establishment of the State and Local Cybersecurity Grant Program (SLCGP), appropriating $1 billion over four years (FY2022-FY2025).[54]

Crucially for SLG strategy, the SLCGP is set to expire on September 30, 2025. Consequently, NASCIO and the National Association of Counties (NACo) are aggressively lobbying Congress for its immediate reauthorization to prevent a severe state cyber defense funding cliff. Strategically, it is critical to note that the SLCGP requires states to pass through 80% of the funding to local governments. This mandate means that the actual procurement opportunities for cybersecurity infrastructure will heavily concentrate at the county and municipal levels, not just the state level.

Simultaneously, the nature of SLG cybersecurity is shifting from perimeter defense to internal data governance and algorithmic integrity, heavily influenced by the rapid adoption of AI. Security leaders are actively advising state governments to direct new cyber funding toward modernizing security operations with agentic AI and automation, moving away from staffing-heavy Security Operations Centers (SOCs) toward autonomous defense mechanisms.[12]

Strategic Programmatic Recommendations for Dell Execution

Based on the exhaustive synthesis of federal funding streams, legislative mandates, and state CIO priorities analyzed in this report, the following strategic technology programs should be developed and pursued by Dell's SLG strategists.

1. Dell Sovereign AI for Program Integrity & Fraud Detection

Alignment: Medicaid Fraud Control Units (MFCUs) $432M operating budgets; 12% federal Medicaid cuts under OBBBA.[3] **Target Audience:** State Attorneys General, State Inspectors General, Health and Human Services (HHS) CIOs. **Program Focus:** Position the **Dell AI Factory with NVIDIA** as the foundational reference design for government program integrity. As states turn to AI to recover billions in fraud, they require highly secure compute environments to analyze Protected Health Information (PHI). Develop a "Sovereign AI" hardware program featuring on-premises GPU-accelerated servers and high-throughput storage arrays. This architecture guarantees data privacy, ownership, and strict compliance with emerging state AI regulations (like Texas's TRAIGA) while offsetting budget cuts.[40]

2. Empowering Education: K-12 Efficiency & Digital Consolidation

Alignment: NGA "Empowering Every Learner" Pillar; OBBBA K-12 budget pressures. **Target Audience:** State Superintendents of Education, Large District CIOs, State IT consolidation task forces. **Program Focus:** With federal education funding cuts and Medicaid reductions squeezing school district budgets, K-12 IT leaders must do more with less. Develop an educational infrastructure program centered on IT consolidation, high-efficiency digital learning platforms, and cost-saving cloud and hardware architectures. Align the messaging with the NGA's focus on future-ready pathways, showcasing how Dell infrastructure reduces TCO while maintaining the necessary bandwidth and device support for modern, hands-on learning environments.[17]

3. The Rural Health Edge & Data Interoperability Initiative

Alignment: $50 Billion Rural Health Transformation Program (RHTP) (OBBBA Sec. 71401).[7] **Target Audience:** State Departments of Health, Rural Healthcare Coalitions, Regional Hospital CIOs. **Program Focus:** Develop bundled Dell infrastructure solutions designed to fulfill the CMS grant requirements for RHTP. The portfolio must focus on decentralized edge compute for remote patient monitoring (RPM), ruggedized hardware for mobile clinics, and secure, hybrid-cloud storage for localized health information exchanges.

4. Mega-Event Situational Awareness & RTCC Architecture

Alignment: $625M FIFA World Cup Grant, $500M C-UAS Grant, DOJ Public Safety Grants.[30] **Target Audience:** Host City Municipal IT Directors, State Police Superintendents, Regional Transit Authorities. **Program Focus:** Position Dell high-performance computing (HPC) and ultra-dense storage solutions as the indispensable backbone of Real-Time Crime Centers (RTCCs). The program must highlight the necessity of edge computing for processing C-UAS radar data and 4K optical feeds locally. Offer flexible commercial models that allow host cities to rapidly expand compute capacity during the 2026 World Cup or 2028 Olympics, and dynamically scale down post-event.

5. Localized Cyber Defense & Agentic Automation

Alignment: NASCIO #2 Priority (Cybersecurity), State and Local Cybersecurity Grant Program (SLCGP) 80% pass-through.[15] **Target Audience:** County IT Directors, Municipal CISOs, State CIOs. **Program Focus:** Because 80% of SLCGP funds must be passed through to local governments, Dell must target county and municipal leaders. Develop solutions that leverage Agentic AI to automate threat detection, log analysis, and compliance reporting. Position these Dell platforms as force multipliers that allow local governments to maximize the impact of their grants while permanently reducing the operational overhead of their SOCs.

6. Next-Generation Aviation Infrastructure (BNATCS) Support

Alignment: $12.5 Billion FAA Modernization (BNATCS).[2] **Target Audience:** Federal Systems Integrators (Primes), Regional Airport Authorities, State Departments of Transportation.

Program Focus: Partner closely with prime integrators to supply the backend compute requirements for BNATCS. Develop a specialized aviation infrastructure program showcasing Dell's MIL-STD compliant, ruggedized rackmount servers, high-availability storage arrays, and robust virtualization hardware necessary for the Tower Simulation Systems (TSS) and Surface Awareness Initiatives (SAI) rolling out to state and local airports.[51]

By aligning Dell's specific hardware, software, and AI Factory capabilities directly with these explicitly funded, legislative mandates, SLG strategy teams can elevate their engagements from transactional IT refresh cycles to mission-critical, federally subsidized transformation partnerships.

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